Fontaine

By Whoopi Goldberg

FONTAINE: "Around the world in eighty days. . ." *(He is singing, dancing, providing percussion sounds. He breaks into a shoo-bop version of the song – See NOTE at the end of this selection for lyrics and music to this song)*

What's happening? *(No answer.)* What's happening? *(No answer.)* Hey look y'all, my name is Fontaine and love is my game.

INTRODUCTION

Germany has spent much of the past 50 years in the excruciating process of dealing with the country's national crimes. What does it mean to come to terms with the fact that your father, even if not a passionate Nazi, did nothing whatever to stop them, but watched silently as his Jewish doctor or neighbor was sent to the ghettos and ultimately the concentration camps. In this selection, a modern-day ex-junkie from the US travels to Europe for the first time and the evidence of the Jewish Holocaust leaves him/her with a new perspective on life and questioning humanity. Fontaine by Whoopi Goldberg

FONTAINE: You know a lot of people can't handle me. I don't understand it, 'cause like, I feel like I'm a friendly person. But you know, some people's attitude really drove me out of the country a while back. No, they did. But I got the kind of gig that allows me the freedom to cruise, because I am a thief. It's the all-American, traditional gig. People always got stuff; people always want stuff; I provide a service.

Checked out these bad apartments. Found me these gold-plated, digital escargot forks. Cashed them little [suckers] in, picked up the cash, went on down to JFK 'cause you know on TV they always tell ya, "Come down to pick up your ticket to Europe." So that's what I did.

And I said to the dude real politely, "Hey, where's my ticket to Europe at?"

And that man looked at me like I farted on his best suit. But he wrote the ticket out. I mean, he handed it to me, you know. I took it and walked away. He come running up behind me talking about how I have ta pay for it first. I said, "What?" I mean, you really expect me to pay before I fly? I'm a business person, okay? If I have a product I want you to buy from me I'm gonna give you a taste first just so you know I stand behind my product. Because that's good business, you know? But the airlines, they don't feel like that. They get your money and get you up in the air and then they [crash the plane], you know? The dude says he gonna call the police on me. So I gave him $956 and I walked ten steps away over to this chick who is standing there looking at me like this. *(Giggling, he makes a pinched, hyper-friendly face)* I said, "What are you grinnin' at?" And she looks at me talking about *(prissy, condescending voice),* "We have a bit of a problem. Now what's happened is we've oversold this flight. Now what that means is that we have a hundred seats on the plane but we've sold tickets to three thousand people. So I guess you're not going anywhere are you?"

Now I pulled [a stunt] that I'm gonna hip you to just in case you find yourself in the same position. 'Cause I got it down, in effect. I said, "Hey," I say, "I been through your pocketbook and I know where you live." And needless to say I got me a seat on the plane. That's right man. I checked my bags through.

We landed in Amsterdam, and I was lucky because I had a map already, you know, tell you all the [places] to go check out. The Diamond Exchange, the Van Gogh Museum, the ballet. . . and in the middle of this long list I see this name that I think I recognize because it said The Anne Frank House. And I wonder if it's the same chick. So I said I'm gonna go check the pad out. So, like I cruise on over to the street that's described on the map, and in the middle of this block is a white brick building. Has a door and a bronze plaque to the right of it that says The Anne Frank House. So I walk in and immediately I'm hip to the fact that it's a museum. And they

got a lady sitting behind the information desk and she got all these pamphlets talking about The Anne Frank House and what to do and why they there. And behind her there were all these huge pictures that look like they suspended in midair. And attached to these pictures are headphones. And the photos are of Amsterdam and Holland during the war, and the headphones give you the narration that goes with the sequence of the photographs. . .

And as I was perusing the area, I noticed a small staircase leading up to a big bookcase, and I'm into books you know, I got a Ph.D. in literature from Columbia. I have an education. I got a Ph.D. I can't do anything with. So I went on up the stairs because I want to see this one book. And I pulled on this book, and when I did that, the bookcase opened up and on the other side was this whole other room. Now, wasn't nobody up there said don't go in and there weren't no signs or nothing, so I walked on in.

And the first thing you see when you're cruising into this room is a row of huge windows and all the windowpanes are blacked out so there ain't no sunlight coming in. And you look at the walls that are surrounding these windows and they are covered in this kind of wallpaper, got little flowers on it. And you get up closer and you can tell at one time it was tan but now of course it's old and brown with age and water spots, and peeling off the walls in strips. And on these walls was pictures of movie stars from like, the thirties and forties-Myrna Loy, Carol Lombard-beautiful black-and-white pictures. And when I was looking at that I happened to turn my head and see the skylight and I said, "Oh my, I'm in the room where Anne Frank's family hid." And that kinda like, threw me. 'Cause this ain't something I was really on top of in terms of history. It wasn't; my forte is American history from the twenties to the present time. Now why is that hard to believe? I mean, I'm a junkie, but I'm not stupid in some respects.

So like, I was checking, you know, the differences because like, here we

knew what was happening, things like the Civil Rights Movement. 'Cause we was ready for that. When I say "we" I mean all the people who was involved in making civil rights happen. Because we knew, as soon as Rosa Parks did not get her [butt] up off that bus, what was coming. We knew. We wasn't quite ready for people getting blown away in cars or little girls getting blown up in churches, but we knew it was gonna be a struggle.

The difference over in Europe is that the Jews wasn't ready. See, they was living and integrating into these areas as well as they could be and they thought of themselves as Germans or Austrians or whatever. And when these people changed on them, started calling them nasty names and turning them in, they turned around and said, "Well hey, we been through this kind of thing before, you know, this is gonna pass." And when they realized what was happening, it was too late. They ended up in the camps, and leaving and going into hiding. And that kinda blew me away, too, because I always thought when you went into hiding it was like moving from one apartment to another. Because everybody I ever knew who went into hiding, I knew where they were. The only people who didn't know was the police. But it was a little bit different 'cause here you get nineteen to twenty-five people in one bedroom, but they can all go outside, you know, cruise around.

But these folks was stuck in this room for two years. And it wasn't like they was living. They got in there, they had twenty hours a day of non-movement. Non-movement. No noise. They sat with no sound.

(Several beats of silence.)

Nerve-wracking, ain't it? Yeah, and I discovered just like you just did that I couldn't do it. See I'd had to make some noise and mess up and I realized that that was really a stupid way to do things' cause why cut off your nose to spite your face? And when that hit me so did the fact that I was in an empty room crying. I said, "No, this don't have nothing to do with me, get out." And I ran to the door, but I got

stopped by a big sign that said: IN SPITE OF EVERYTHING I STILL BELIEVE PEOPLE ARE GOOD AT HEART. I said "What?" I mean, who put this up? Why would they put it in this room? I just couldn't understand it. So I copped an attitude and decided to write a letter to the author of the quote. So I got up close enough to see the author's name and my jaw dropped 'cause it said Anne Frank. And I thought, this is too childish for words! What are you talking about? You didn't even make it! And as soon as I said that it made perfect sense. Of course Anne Frank could say that, she was a child, she was a kid, and you know no matter what you do to children they always able to still see some good in it, see? 'Cause they got that ability to see the light at the end of the tunnel.

I don't have it. I'm what you call jaded. And I thought, yeah, man. What can I say? And I started examining my own [life], you know. What are my day-to-day worries? Things like, Why can't I get an American Express card? Why can't I find a hairdresser to mess with my coif? These are my big day-to-day worries, but then you go into a room like this and you hold your coif and your card up against life and death and you know the true meaning of trivial pursuit.

So, I decided what I was gonna do was try to adopt this philosophy somehow, this "in spite of everything. . ." because it might help me in case I got home and I caught some [idiot] in my house ripping off my stereo. Yes, I would still break their legs, but I would remember that in spite of everything this person is still good at heart and that would save their life. So I decided, and I figured that it was cool, and I needed to see the other side of that, 'cause this is only half of the story. So I took the train from Amsterdam into Germany, and going to Germany was a whole other trip 'cause I didn't go to big cities. I went to little, tiny towns, places in the Schwarzfeld which is the black forest, and me and the black forest was it.

Some of these people ain't seen no black people since Hannibal. And as a matter of fact, I get off the train, I have five or six little kids running up on me biting on my

arms talking about *(In a German accent),* "Ooh, choco-latte." And you start talking to all these people and you find out that a lot of these folks are born in these villages, raised in these villages and they gonna die in these villages. And they don't go nowhere.

And people come up on you and say weird [stuff] like, "We see how, on the American documentaries, see how it is for the black people in the United States. Please to tell us how it is for you to live in the ghetto and please eat this watermelon, we got it special for you." And you know I have to say I was really surprised to discover such. . . to hear those people say watermelon kinda freaked me out. . . to discover such rampant ignorance in the world, 1983-84, especially coming from the United States where such a thing would never happen. I mean we're beyond that subject, right? Yeah, yeah. . .

I said, "Oh my, I got to get home." Because I'm there with the wrong attitude, you know. 'Cause I'm walking around looking for bombed-out buildings, saying shit to people, talking about, "Why you fighting this terrible war?" Could not even see 1983. I said, "I gotta get [it] together.

I'm had a lot of time to think . . . I'm one of these people, you know where if you don't speak English don't come up to me in the street and ask me where [stuff] is. Yeah, you the same way, right? "Yeah, go talk to somebody who know what the hell you talking about . . . come over here take my job . . . " Yeah, well you know it's real hard to be that cold once you been the alien. See, and once you been the alien, you find out how hard it is to have to ask somebody where shit is. And you find out what it takes to be able to tell them. It don't take nothing but a little bit of graciousness, that's it. Just a little bit. And that coupled with everything else that happened to me kinda freaked me out. Because I realized that life is a constant thing, it's constant live and learn. I'll never get over that.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2002 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier

NOTE: The music and lyrics to Around the World in 80 Days can be found at
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=98OvpEnjnTg